

Survey report by Finextra Research

April 2026

Finextra®

NAVIGATING THE NORDIC FINANCIAL LANDSCAPE: 2026 CHALLENGES AND PRIORITIES



Navigating the Nordic financial landscape: 2026 challenges and priorities

Building on Finextra's Navigating the Nordic financial landscape 2025 survey, our 2026 version captures and explores ongoing priorities within the Nordics. As the Nordic financial sector faces new hurdles and opportunities, a variety of issues are front and centre for financial institutions, fintech firms, and technology providers.

Finextra's survey of 172 industry professionals reveals how organisations across Sweden, Denmark, Finland, Iceland, and Norway are navigating the current financial landscape and their strategic priorities for 2026. Providing valuable insights into areas such as fraud management priorities, perspectives on Central Bank Digital Currencies (CBDCs) and stablecoins, quantum computing, synthetic data, the modernisation of payments infrastructure, Digital Operational Resilience Act (DORA), regulation vs innovation budgets, AI's growing role, and emerging technologies like programmable payments and tokenisation.

Key takeaways and recommendations

01 Strategic focus broadens

Nordic institutions are balancing multiple priorities in 2026, with customer experience improvements taking the lead and accelerating technology adoption remaining a strong priority this year. Combatting payment fraud now sits alongside a wider agenda compared to our 2025 results, suggesting not reduced importance, but a more complex landscape where institutions must juggle multiple focus areas.

02 Legacy infrastructure slows Nordic payments interoperability

Legacy infrastructure ranks as the greatest barrier to achieving a truly interoperable future-ready Nordic payments ecosystem, with competitive tensions and regulatory fragmentation adding friction. Cross-border coordination concerns further highlight the need for stronger collaboration and market alignment across the Nordics.

03 AI and quantum fuel a new era of fraud

Fraud is no longer isolated — AI is scaling attacks across social engineering, deepfakes, synthetic identities, and traditional fraud. Awareness of quantum computing risks is also rising alongside AI-driven threats, though deep preparedness remains limited, signalling the need for early cryptographic resilience planning. Over the next 12 months, Nordic fraud priorities are focused on securing payment environments using advanced technologies, and scaling fraud prevention to match growing transaction volumes — reflecting the need to balance fraud resilience alongside an increasingly broad set of strategic priorities.

04 Programmable payments and tokenised assets gain momentum

Over 80% of institutions are actively piloting or planning deployment. The greatest value is placed on conditional, automated flows and integration via APIs or smart contracts, underlining that strategic advantage comes from embedding innovation into core operations — not just faster payments.

05 Regulatory resilience matures

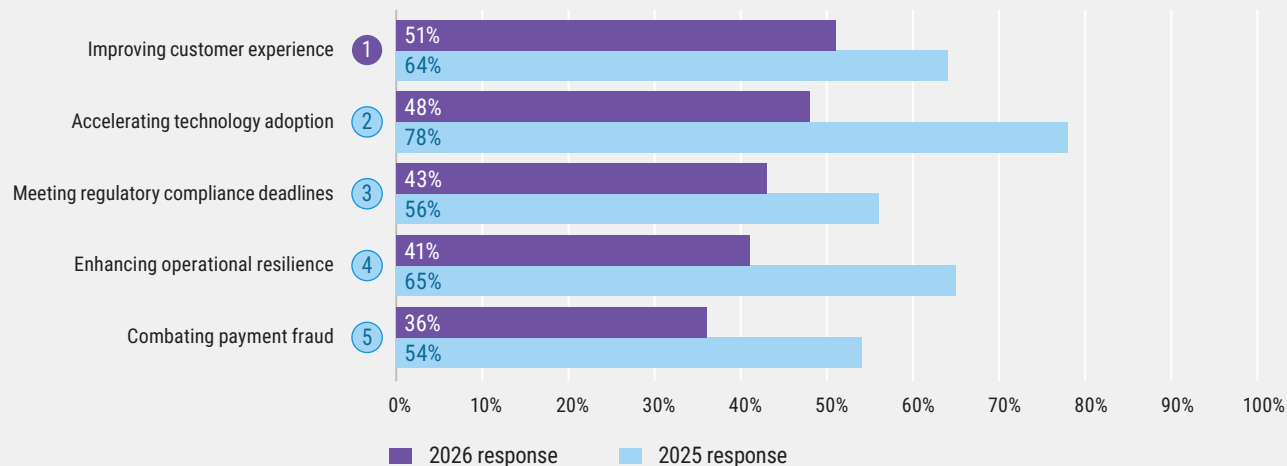
Sentiment around DORA is maturing, with fewer organisations meeting just the minimum compliance compared to 2025, indicating a shift toward embedded cyber and operational resilience frameworks. Organisations are evenly investing in compliance and innovation, with most allocating 21-30% of budgets to each. This signals a strategic approach to how technological advancements can help meet regulatory demands more efficiently.

01 Looking to the year ahead

TOTAL RESPONSE

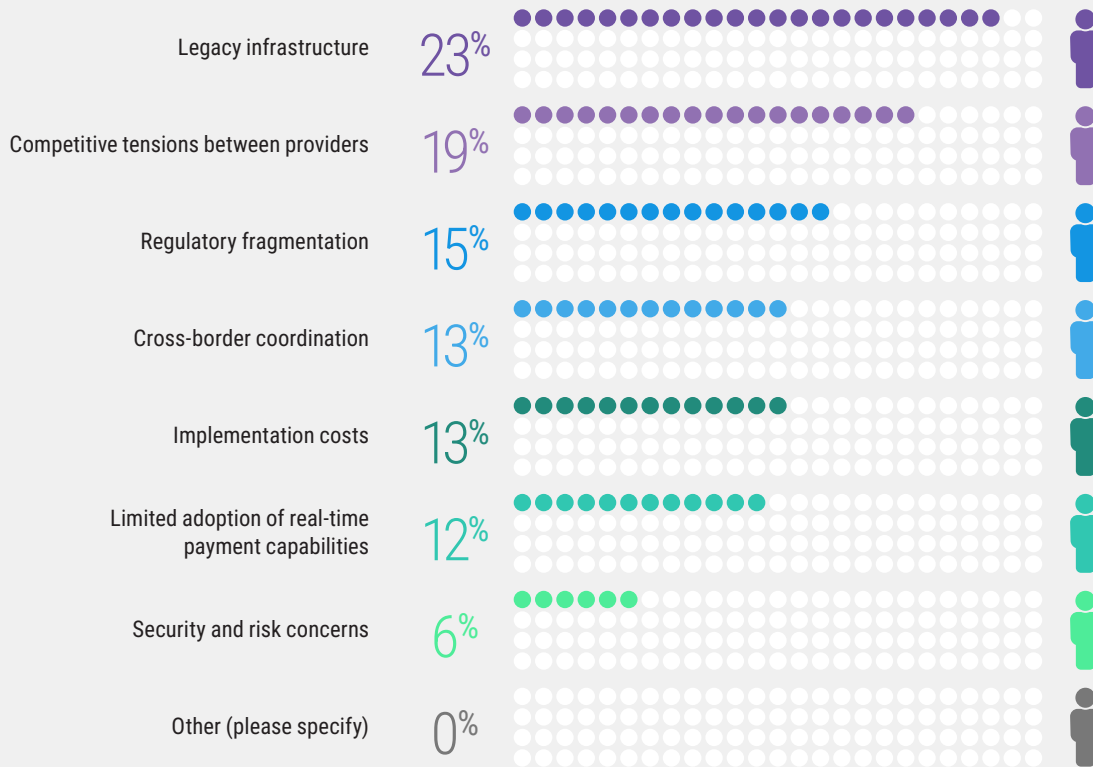
What are your organisation's key focus areas for 2026?

Please select all that apply



Nordic financial institutions are maintaining a strong focus on strategic transformation, though priorities appear to be broadening heading into 2026. Accelerating technology adoption was the clear top priority in 2025 (78%), however, focus has now become more evenly distributed, with improving customer experience (51%) leading the agenda. Overall, lower scores across all categories for this year suggest a shift from intense, across-the-board prioritisation, to a more measured and balanced approach.

TOTAL RESPONSE

What is the greatest barrier to achieving a truly interoperable future-ready Nordic payments ecosystem?

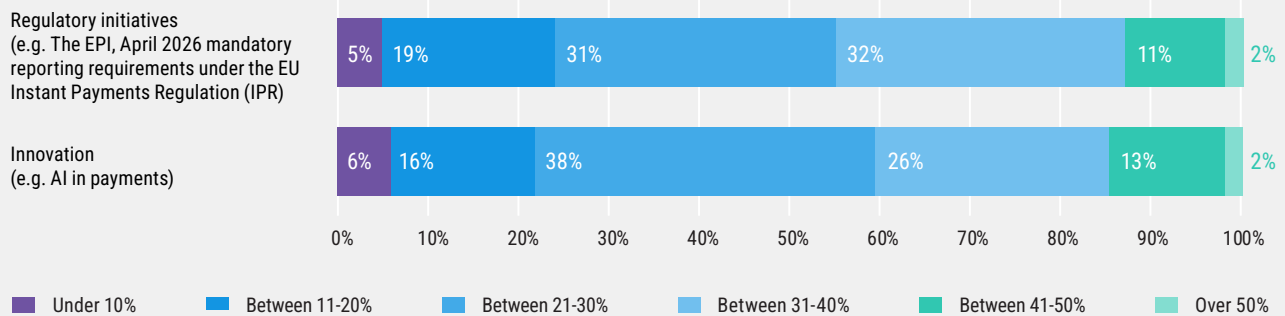
The dominant barrier to achieving a truly interoperable future-ready Nordic payments ecosystem does not lie in an isolated weakness, but in a combination of pressures.

Legacy infrastructure leads, reflecting how deeply embedded systems continue to slow progress, followed by competitive tensions between providers and regulatory fragmentation. Cross-border coordination and implementation costs add operational friction, while limited adoption of real-time payments points to differing levels of market maturity. Security concerns rank comparatively low, indicating how Nordic institutions see alignment and collaboration as the primary progress blockers.

01 Looking to the year ahead

TOTAL RESPONSE

Approximately what percentage of your organisation's 2026 budgets are allocated to regulatory initiatives vs innovation?



Figures are rounded to the nearest whole percentage.

There is a balanced and intentional allocation of resources across both regulatory and innovation priorities. For most organisations, neither area is viewed as marginal (under 10% of 2026 budgets) nor disproportionately dominant (over 50% of 2026 budgets), underscoring a measured and strategic approach across the Nordics.

The equal budget allocation reflects an acknowledgment of the two pressing needs in the sector: keeping up with regulations while also pushing for technology innovation. The key takeaway is that focusing on innovation doesn't mean sidelining compliance. The real challenge now is making sure resources are used wisely to tackle this complex environment.

REGIONAL RESPONSE

Sweden

- Top focus areas for 2026 are customer experience (66%) followed by technology adoption (58%).
- The main barrier to achieving a truly interoperable future-ready Nordic payments ecosystem is legacy infrastructure (34%), the highest score across the Nordics.

Denmark

- Customer experience is the greatest focus area (57%), while combating payment fraud scores the lowest across the Nordics (26%).
- The main barriers to achieving a truly interoperable future-ready Nordic payments ecosystem are split between regulatory fragmentation and implementation costs, both 23%, the highest scores across the Nordics.

Finland

- Technology adoption is the top priority (53%), followed by improving customer experience (50%).
- The main barriers to achieving a truly interoperable future-ready Nordic payments ecosystem are competitive tensions between providers (21%), followed by legacy infrastructure and regulatory fragmentation (both 18%).

Iceland

- Technology adoption ranks as the highest priority (44%), while operational resilience scores the lowest across the Nordics (31%).
- The key barrier to achieving a truly interoperable future-ready Nordic payments ecosystem is cross-border coordination (25%), ranking 11 percentage point above other Nordic countries.

Norway

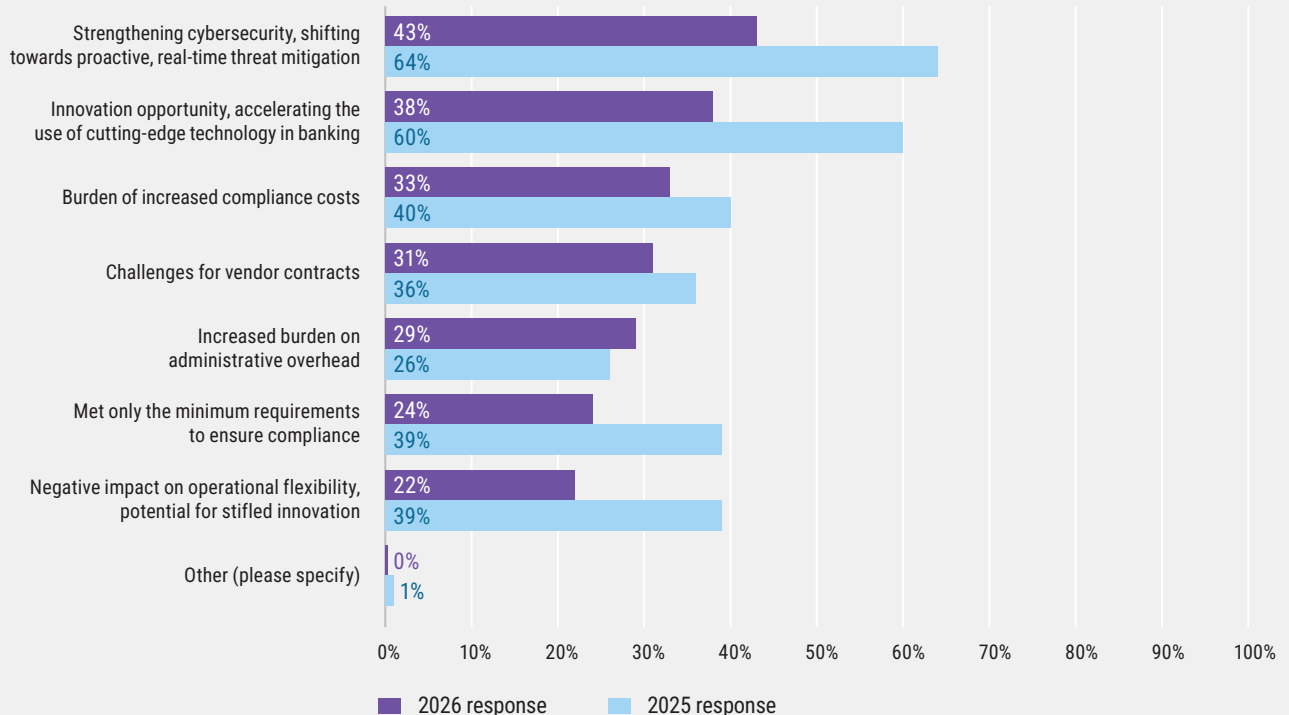
- Operational resilience is the top priority, the highest scores across the Nordics (59%).
- The main barrier to achieving a truly interoperable future-ready Nordic payments ecosystem is legacy infrastructure (27%), and limited adoption of real-time payments (24%), ranking 9 percentage points above other Nordic countries.

Future proofing operational resilience and fraud management

TOTAL RESPONSE

How has DORA (Digital Operational Resilience Act) helped you prepare for resilience against risks such as cyberattacks and/or cross border outages?

Please select all that apply

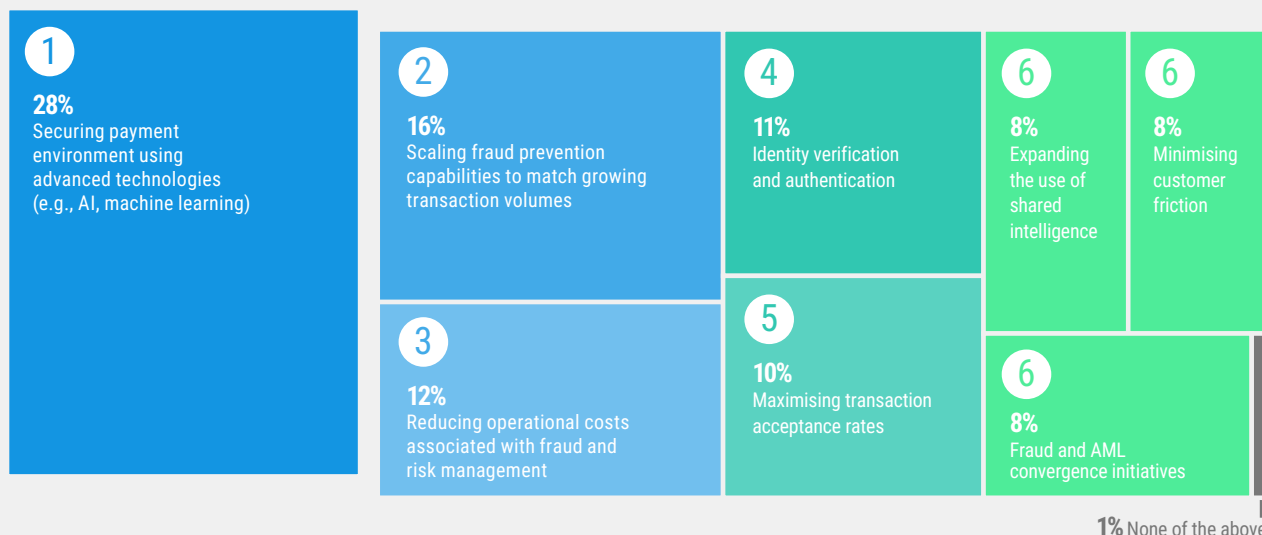


Sentiment around DORA (Digital Operational Resilience Act) is maturing as Nordic institutions move from early expectations to practical implementation. In 2026, fewer organisations view DORA primarily as a driver of cybersecurity and innovation compared with 2025, despite the high-ranking scores, suggesting the initial optimism is giving way to other operational realities.

Notably, the share of institutions meeting ‘only the minimum requirements to ensure compliance’ has dropped significantly, indicating that firms are moving beyond box-ticking toward more embedded resilience frameworks.

TOTAL RESPONSE

What is your organisation's top strategic priority in fraud management for the next 12 months?



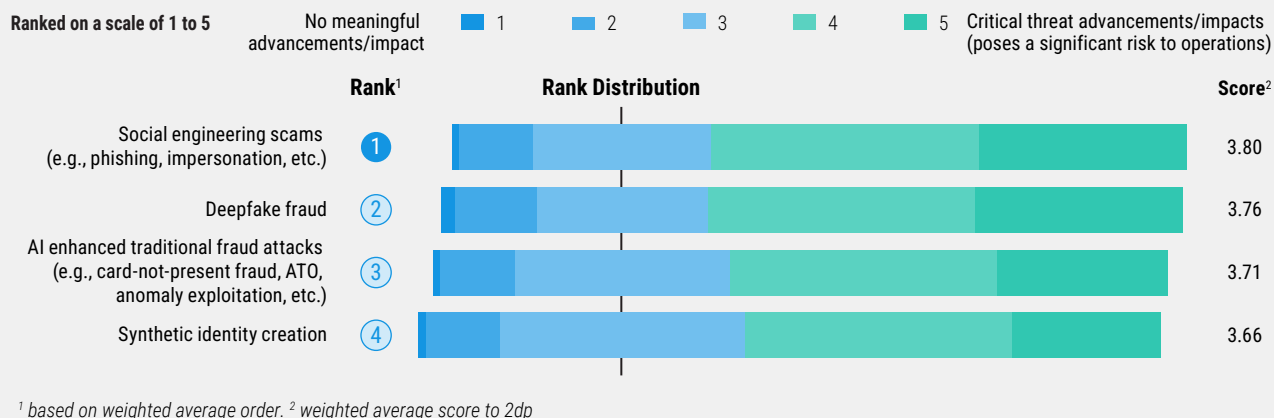
As Nordic institutions move beyond reactive fraud controls toward scalable, technology-enabled defences, the real challenge will be deploying these tools in ways that strengthen security without constraining growth or customer experience.

More than a quarter of organisations (28%) identify securing the payments environment through advanced technologies as their top strategic priority in fraud management for the next 12 months, signalling a clear shift toward intelligence-driven defence. The next tier of priorities reflects the operational realities of a rapidly expanding digital economy: scaling fraud prevention capabilities to match growing transaction volumes and reducing the operational costs associated with fraud and risk management.

02 Future proofing operational resilience and fraud management

TOTAL RESPONSE

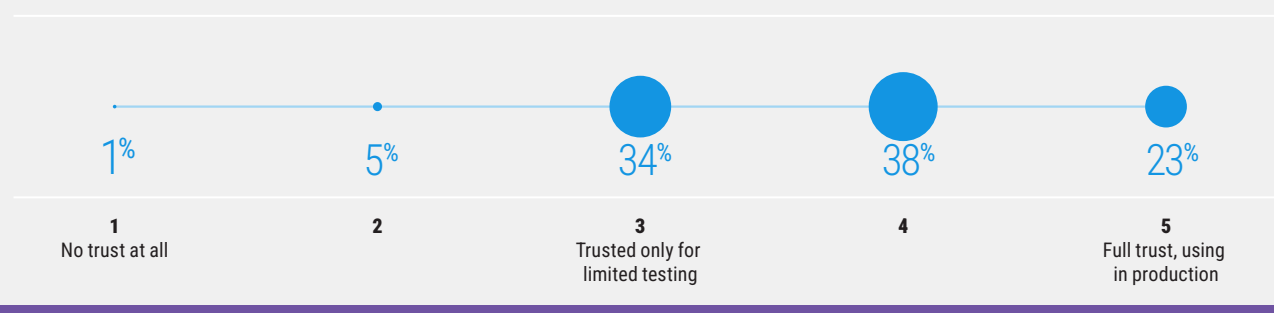
For specific fraud vectors, where are you seeing the most significant advances/impacts as fraudsters adopt AI tools and tactics?



As fraudsters adopt AI tools and tactics, the impact felt across Nordic organisations is rated as consistently significant. Every fraud vector scores an average of 3.66 or above out of 5, and all sit within a narrow 0.14 range. The message is clear for industry leaders — AI is shifting fraud from isolated incidents to attackers now able to target victims and personalise scams at scale.

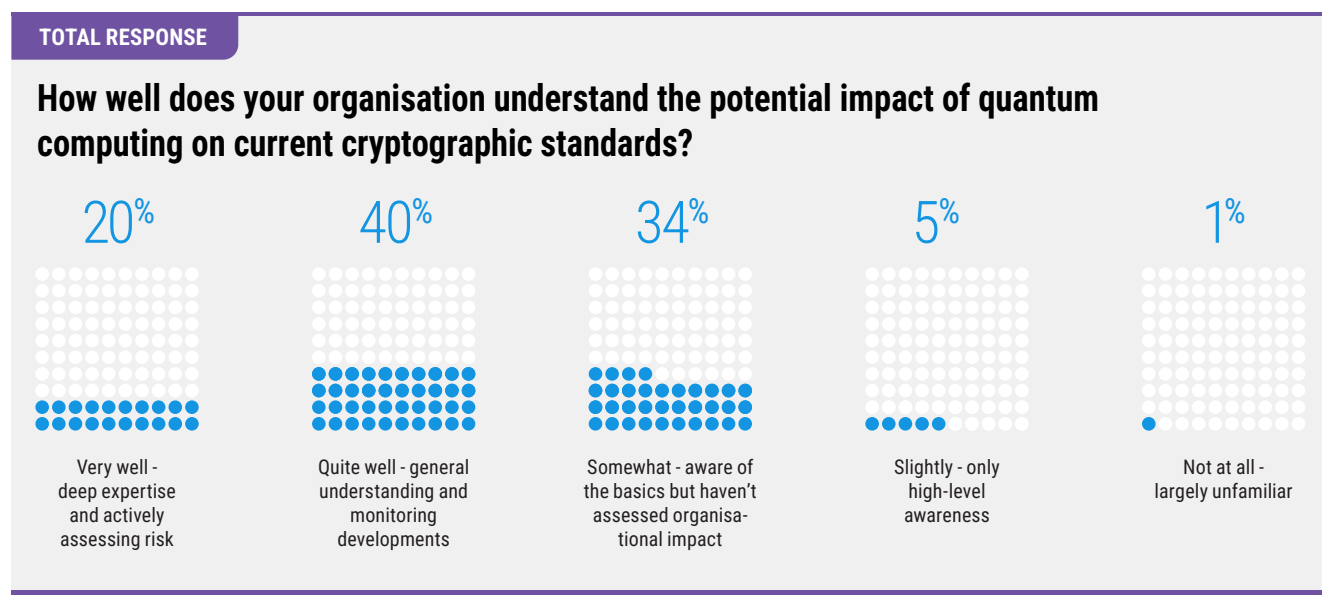
TOTAL RESPONSE

How much does your organisation trust AI-generated datasets to train fraud detection models without exposing sensitive information?



Trust in AI-generated datasets for training fraud detection models without exposing sensitive information remains a nuanced challenge for Nordic financial institutions. While there is a level of optimism, with 94% expressing some level of trust (sum of scale 3-5), the 34% with trust 'only for limited testing' highlights how data sensitivity and security concerns persist.

As institutions navigate this complex landscape, the question remains: how can they effectively build and communicate trust in AI systems to drive broader adoption and effectiveness?



The potential impact of quantum computing on current cryptographic standards is increasingly on the radar, but strong knowledge and preparedness remain limited across Nordic financial institutions. While one in five report deep expertise and actively assessing risk, the majority are still in observation mode, with 40% saying they have a general understanding and are monitoring developments. A further 34% acknowledge only a basic awareness without having evaluated the organisational impact.

Those that start assessing their cryptographic exposure and planning a transition to quantum-resistant security now will be better placed to avoid a last-minute scramble as both the technology and the regulatory focus around it continues to accelerate.

02 Future proofing operational resilience and fraud management

REGIONAL RESPONSE

Sweden

- DORA is seen as strengthening cybersecurity, but also increasing administrative burden and costs.
- Top fraud priority is securing payment environments using advanced technologies (32%).
- The most significant advances are seen in social engineering scams as fraudsters adopt AI tools (3.74/5).
- 53% understand quantum risks 'very/quite well', though only 18% report deep expertise.

Denmark

- Nearly half (49%) see DORA as an innovation opportunity, while 37% highlight stronger cybersecurity.
- Securing payment environments using advanced technologies (26%) and cost reduction (20%) tops fraud priorities.
- Social engineering scams (4.06/5) and synthetic identity creation (4.03/5) see the most significant advances as fraudsters adopt AI tools.
- Over a quarter (26%) understand quantum risks 'very well', the highest across the Nordics.

Finland

- DORA strengthens cybersecurity but raises vendor management challenges and compliance costs.
- Scaling prevention capabilities to match growing transaction volumes (21%) is the top fraud priority.
- AI is accelerating traditional fraud attacks (3.88/5) and social engineering scams (3.62/5) the most.
- 59% report understanding quantum risks 'very/quite well'.

Iceland

- DORA improves cyber resilience (38%) but operational flexibility and administrative overhead concerns remain.
- Securing payment environments using advanced technologies (28%) and customer friction reduction (16%) are the top fraud priorities.
- Deepfake fraud sees the most significant advances as fraudsters adopt AI tools (4.0/5).
- 44% have a basic awareness of quantum risks but haven't assessed organisational impact, the highest across the Nordics.

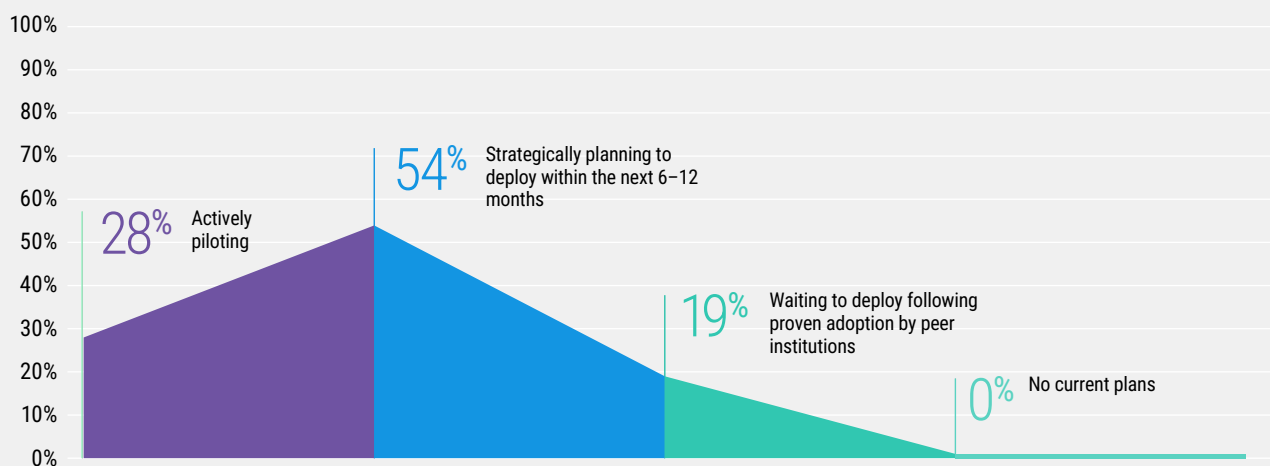
Norway

- DORA strengthens cybersecurity (47%) but increases compliance costs and administrative burden.
- Greatest fraud strategy focus scores across the Nordics for securing payment environments using advanced technologies (38%).
- Social engineering scams (3.82/5) and synthetic identity creation (3.59/5) see the most significant advances as fraudsters adopt AI tools.
- 68% report a 'very/quite well', understanding of quantum risks, the highest score across the Nordics for 'quite well'.

03 The next wave of Nordic payments

TOTAL RESPONSE

What is your organisation's current timeline for programmable payments and tokenised assets?

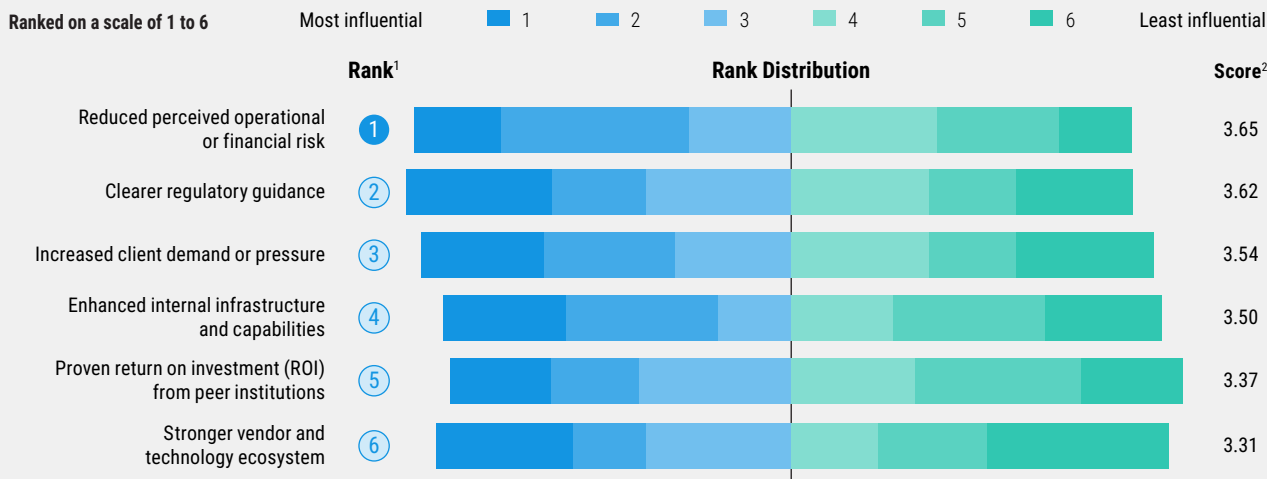


Our survey data points to an accelerating shift toward programmable payments and tokenised assets, with 82% either actively piloting or strategically planning to be first movers. Meanwhile, nearly one in five (19%) are waiting to deploy following proven adoption by peer institutions. Zero respondents indicate 'no current plans', highlighting widespread recognition of the strategic importance of programmable payments and tokenised assets in an increasingly digital and competitive payments ecosystem.

03 The next wave of Nordic payments

TOTAL RESPONSE

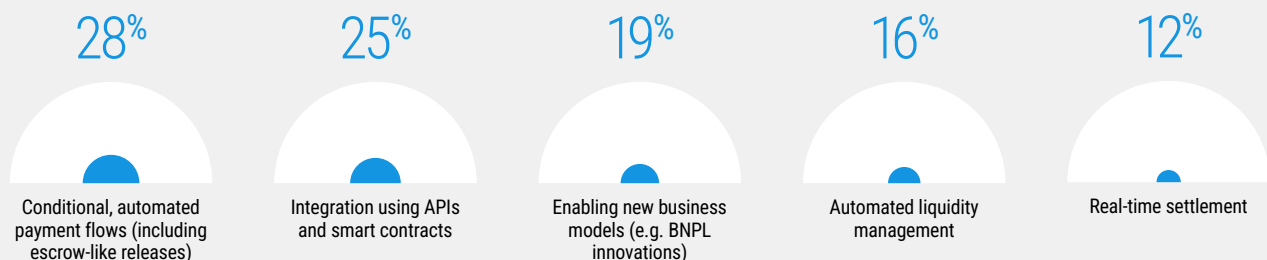
Which factors would most accelerate the adoption of stablecoins for commercial use cases?



Looking at specific drivers of stablecoin adoption for commercial use cases, our survey finds that notably, all factors sit within a narrow 0.34 range from the highest to lowest weighted average, showcasing how adoption is not driven by one overriding factor. As with most new innovations, reduced perceived operational or financial risk will accelerate adoption in the first instance. Regulatory clarity follows, likely because existing pieces of regulation (for example MiCA in the EU), have already started the momentum on the legal frameworks that will bring digital assets into the mainstream.

TOTAL RESPONSE

Which aspect of programmable payments and tokenised assets are most valuable?



For Nordic institutions, the greatest value in programmable payments and tokenised assets lies in automation and integration rather than pure speed. Conditional, automated payment flows — such as escrow-style releases — emerge as the top opportunity, closely followed by API and smart contract integration, signalling strong interest in embedding payments directly into digital platforms and workflows. By contrast, benefits often associated with next-generation payment infrastructure, such as real-time settlement, rank lower.

REGIONAL RESPONSE

Sweden

- The majority are planning programmable payments and tokenised assets deployment within 6-12 months (53%), with a notable group 'actively piloting' (34%).
- Regulatory clarity is the main stablecoin adoption accelerator.
- The greatest value in programmable payments and tokenised assets is placed on conditional, automated payment flows and new business models.

Denmark

- Leads the Nordics with the highest 'actively piloting' score (40%) for programmable payments and tokenised assets.
- Stablecoin adoption drivers are balanced across vendor and technology ecosystems, client demand, ROI, and internal capability.
- Places the greatest value in conditional, automated payment flows across the Nordics for programmable payments and tokenised assets.

Finland

- Largely in the planning stage (65%), with fewer 'actively piloting' programmable payments and tokenised assets.
- Regulatory clarity and reduced risk are key to accelerating stablecoin adoption.
- Value in programmable payments and tokenised assets is spread across conditional payments, API integration, and liquidity management.

Iceland

- More cautious programmable payments and tokenised assets deployment, with equal shares for 'actively piloting' and waiting for peer adoption (31%).
- Greater emphasis on vendor and technology ecosystem maturity for accelerating stablecoin adoption.
- API/smart-contract integration and liquidity management is the most valuable aspect of programmable payments and tokenised assets.

Norway

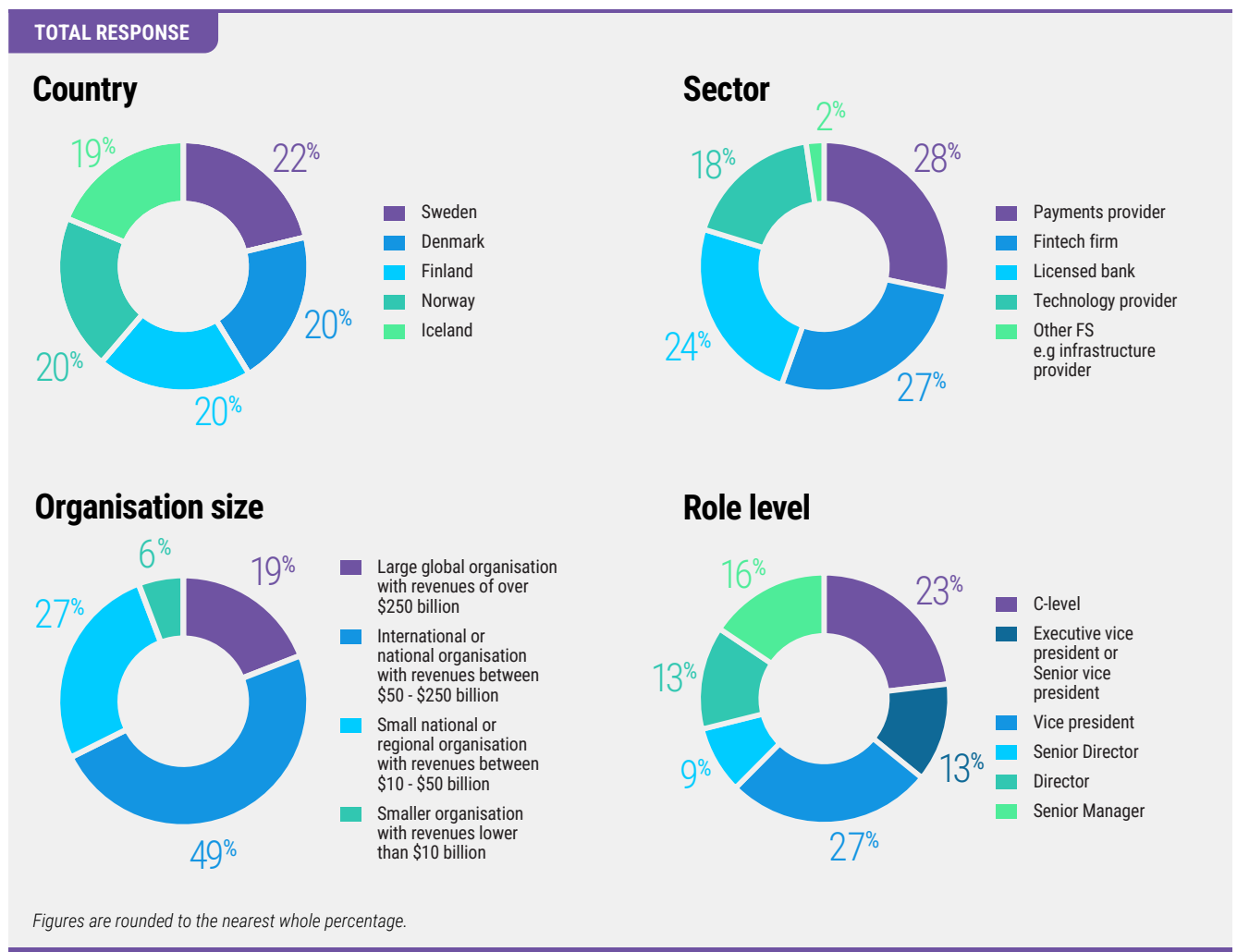
- Strong pipeline of planned deployments (68%) but the lowest score across the Nordics for 'actively piloting' (15%) programmable payments and tokenised assets.
- Regulation and client demand are the key stablecoin adoption drivers.
- APIs/smart contract integration and conditional payment flows are seen as the main value areas for programmable payments and tokenised assets.

About the survey report

Finextra Research surveyed 172 Nordic industry professionals between February - March 2026 across Sweden, Denmark, Finland, Iceland, and Norway. Survey respondents held roles with titles ranging from c-level, executive vice president or senior vice president, senior director, director, and senior manager, across payments providers, fintech firms, licensed banks, technology providers, and other financial services (e.g infrastructure providers) within revenues between less than \$10 billion to over \$250 billion.

The full sample breakdown by country, sector, organisation size, and role level are shown below.

All interviews were conducted on a confidential basis.



About

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